

The Messiah OF HATE

Varun Gandhi's diatribe against the minorities has divided his party and given fresh ammunition to its opponents but the young, brash Gandhi scion was working to a plan

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

"These people have scary names like Kareemullah and Mazaharulla. You will be scared if you run into them in the night. But if anyone raises a finger against Hindus or if someone thinks Hindus are weak, I swear on the Gita that I will cut that hand."

—Varun Gandhi

If the last name of the BJP candidate from Pilibhit in Uttar Pradesh had been something else, Varun Gandhi's vitriol against the minorities would have been dismissed as the rantings of a political madcap. But 29-year-old Varun was born into envious privileged family with a surname that forever guaranteed him a place in the country's politics. Though relegated to the sidelines for long on account of his roots on the wrong side of the clan, Varun is enjoying his moment in the sun. Almost overnight, wittingly or otherwise, he has fashioned himself as the latest poster-boy for Hindutva. Those close to him say Varun now appears to be a young man struggling with his inner conflicts: at times wondering if people may actually hate him for his provocative speeches; at others, a self-assured man, who stands by what he said, putting the courage of his convictions

before political correctness. However, beyond the confusion, Varun has proved to be shrewd enough to convert adversity into his biggest opportunity. Perhaps even he did not reckon that his speeches would so swiftly lead him into the limelight he had always yearned for and which eluded him.

Among the more rabid elements in the BJP, he is suddenly being talked of in the same breath as Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi. When a senior party leader told Varun that he was now being compared to Modi, the young man asked him, "Not to my father?" The impact of the question was not lost on the leader. Varun was barely three months old when his father Sanjay Gandhi, who pioneered the era of brash politics, died in a plane crash in 1980. He was two when his widowed 26-year-old mother Maneka Gandhi took on Indira Gandhi—said to be the most powerful woman in the world then. Maneka and her infant son were promptly thrown out of the family into which she had married. At age three, Varun became a party to his first legal case, relating

to family property. Now, he is fighting the most crucial legal case of his life. With the Allahabad High Court dismissing his petition for quashing of the FIR against him, he is gearing up for a long-drawn battle.

Varun has not only polarised the people of Pilibhit but also the BJP. The party first distanced itself from the debutant candidate and told the Election Commission (EC) that it disassociates itself from Varun's utterances. Sources in the party say that when the controversy erupted, Leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani was livid. He was not in favour of letting Varun get away with it. But he could do little as the RSS came out in firm support of Varun, asking Advani to back off. BJP President Rajnath Singh also backed Varun, saying that removing him as the party candidate would be a setback for BJP's Hindutva agenda. The Varun effect has percolated and the BJP is said to have received requests from over 200 constituencies to send Varun to campaign for the party.

Yet, the question remains. How could a young man who holds a post-graduate degree in public policy from the London School of Economics and who has a bright political future ahead indulge in such diatribe and rant? Varun's speech in Pilibhit was an attack not only on all that India, but even his own party, stands for. But there was no sign of remorse. On the contrary, like a typical politician he

Varun's campaign speeches were crafted with the intention of polarising the 15 lakh voters of Pilibhit among communal lines.